

restricted to Bacon and Shakespeare but was used for over a century after their deaths. However, this cipher is impossible to use now due to standardization of the text for publishing which is pre-set.

Musical ciphers

Quite uncommon was the musical cipher where musicians exchanged notes of music for the letters of alphabet. Two people can converse by merely playing a few notes on the piano. They can be involved to a point of no return. The trick is to mildly alter the composition without changing the arrangement. However, the scope of musical cipher is largely limited. It was believed that many such music compositions by Sir Francis Bacon are existent even now.

Picture this

The pictorial cipher was quite popular and is basically a picture or diagram which reveals more than its obvious meaning. Egyptian symbolism is rich in pictorial ciphers and diagrams of alchemists and philosophers reveal hidden layers. The detailing in the images can make a cipher of this sort rather complicated. For example, codes can be hidden in the ripples on the surface of water or by the number of stones in a wall. Montaigne's Essays use the pictorial cipher rather wisely. The initial B is formed with the help of two arches and an F aided by a broken arch. Sometimes, these pictures are accompanied with a key. This was used extensively in art to show meaning in the depths of colour.

Popular examples of pictorial ciphers include Leonardo Da Vinci's Last Supper which created a furore over the relationship between Jesus and Mary Magdalene as well as the hotly debated fifth finger on the Pope's hand in Raphael's Sistine Madonna. The same artist chose to add a sixth toe on Joseph's foot in his painting, Marriage of the Virgin. These are brilliantly concealed cryptograms.

Religious ciphers

Acroamatic ciphers were the religious and physical writings of all nations, where allegories and parables are often the sources of cryptography. Since time immemorial, parables and allegories have been used to present the truth in an easy-to-understand manner. This is a pictorial cipher drawn in words and understood through symbolism. It includes the Old and New Testaments of the Jews, the works of Plato and Aristotle, Homer's Odyssey